Writing Project 2: Draft 1
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Reqs. : Intro, Lit Review, Methods [500-1000 words]

A large part of the internet is held up by work nobody is paid for; there are many open-source libraries maintained in the free time of programmers, many answers posted to help forums, documentation written by volunteers. It has been debated in the world of research if these unpaid contributions to digital spaces are exploitation or innovation, but there is a problem with the scope of this research. Frequently, research tends to center outside observers, users, and the platforms that profit from the free labor they provide. Instead, this study addresses a gap in this research, the perspective of the developers who build and maintain these systems and how they see free digital labor, and even the labor they participate in themselves. This study aims to answer this, how do online developer communities perceive free digital labor?

To preface this study's main question, it helps to review what is already known and researched about free digital labor. Free digital labor can be defined as unpaid contributions to digital spaces. This covers social media posts and comments, open-source software, volunteer initiatives, almost anything contributed to the internet without monetary gain. Research frequently frames social media labor dynamics as exploitative: "[T]hese firms have succeeded in creating ecosystems in which users participate in the production of data, information and content which are then valued by the firms through advertising or the sale of other services" (Vercellone and Di Stasio 340). In other words, users that make posts and comments on social media platforms generate value for the platform itself without compensation. Shi Yibin makes a similar argument stating the following: "network users can create a large amount of surplus value for network media" (qtd. in Yang xi). Another source mention the benefits of free digital labor, namely Deng's article about the free digital labor of local guides, stating that a service like Google Maps is "constantly updated through real-time data from its network of Local Guides" (Deng). Due to the frequent updates Google Maps receives according to Deng, the general public is provided an easily accessible mode of GPS that is both accurate and reliable. This point stretches to social media as well. Even though users may be exploited for their user-generated content that they create for the platform without compensation, they also receive the most powerful way to connect with people ever created.

The primary data for this study was gathered through Reddit on the subreddit "r/programming", searching up topics like free labor and open-source to find discussion posts and comments to collect and analyze. "r/programming" was selected due to its large size and high quantity of developers, and has many references to topics that resonate strongly with this study's research question. Posts were selected based on this relevance after searches conducted with Reddit's built-in search feature. The collected posts date from [start] to [end]. This study analyzed [number] comments analyzed through a coding schema developed for this research. There are two coding dimensions; the first dimension captures the commenter's position on free digital labor. This is coded in four different ways. They are either supportive, opposed, have mixed feelings towards it, or completely neutral. To clarify further, mixed means that the comment expresses both positive and negative views, and neutral means it expresses no view. The second dimension captures the commenter's belief in who benefits from free digital labor. This dimension has six possibilities: the community benefits, the corporations benefit, the individual who is laboring benefits, everyone benefits, nobody benefits, or the comment does not state their belief in this matter.

Secondary data for this study was collected through the online UCF Library, using the same keywords (open-source, free labor) for the search feature. Previously demonstrated in the background section, secondary data exists in this study to pull relevant events to synthesize with analysis of the primary data. They will also help supply definitions and provide the exploitation versus innovation debate that frames this analysis. The data found during the search process was screened for information regarding free digital labor and useful topics and events that could be referenced later on in this analysis; for example, the Google Maps community mapping initiative mentioned in Deng's article is what would be defined as a useful topic, and it will be helpful when looking at corporations in the space of free digital labor.